

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Aviation English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For aviation operations managers, airline staff, maintenance coordinators, safety teams, dispatchers, airport operations staff, ground handlers, and aviation-adjacent professionals.

Workplace coordination English. This course does not teach radiotelephony phraseology or certify aviation language proficiency; operational communication follows approved aviation procedures.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

aircraft routing

The planned sequence of flights assigned to an aircraft.

airworthiness

Condition in which an aircraft conforms to approved design and is safe for operation under applicable rules.

audit

A systematic examination of evidence against defined requirements or criteria.

badge

An identification credential used as part of an organization's access process.

compliance

Conformance with laws, regulations, standards, policies, contracts, or approved procedures.

corrective action

Action taken to fix a current problem and prevent recurrence.

crew legality

Whether a crew assignment meets the applicable duty, rest, and other operating requirements.

damage assessment

An examination of what was damaged and the extent of the damage.

deferred maintenance

Maintenance postponed under the applicable authorized conditions and process.

delay code

A standardized category used to record the reason for an operational delay.

dispatch

Coordinating and assigning resources for an operational task.

escort

An authorized person accompanying someone in an area where access is controlled.

ground handling

Services supporting aircraft and passengers on the ground between flights.

hazard

A potential source of harm.

incident report

A structured record of an event, available facts, and relevant follow-up information.

IROP

Irregular operations: disruptions that affect an airline's planned service.

load sheet

An aircraft loading record used under the operator's approved weight-and-balance procedures.

logbook

A chronological record of operations, maintenance, or other required events.

MEL

Minimum equipment list identifying aircraft equipment that may be inoperative under specified conditions while the aircraft remains dispatchable.

misconnect

A missed onward flight connection.

ramp safety

Safe coordination of work in aircraft ground-service areas under approved procedures.

reaccommodation

Arranging alternative travel for passengers whose original journey is disrupted.

reporting culture

Shared expectations that encourage people to raise concerns and report relevant events.

root cause

Underlying reason a problem occurred, not merely the visible symptom.

safety management system

An organized framework for managing safety responsibilities, risks, reporting, and improvement.

secure area

A location where entry and activities are controlled under defined security requirements.

stop work

A call or authorized action to pause work when a safety concern requires attention under local procedures.

training record

A record of completed instruction, participation, or assessed competence.

turnaround

The ground period and activities between an aircraft's arrival and next departure.

weather delay

An operational delay attributed to weather conditions under the relevant reporting process.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Safety Culture and Stop-Work Authority

In a ground-operations language exercise, a team member sees a possible hazard near equipment. The local safety process applies.

I see a possible hazard near the equipment. Please alert the responsible person and follow the local safety process. I'll state the location and observation clearly so the concern can be assessed.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

02 | Operations Control and Dispatch Coordination

An operations update has a provisional aircraft assignment and an unresolved crew-status question. A draft message calls the plan confirmed.

The aircraft assignment is provisional, and crew status still needs confirmation. I'll distinguish those open items from confirmed information in the operations update.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

03 | Maintenance Deferrals and MEL Language

A maintenance coordination note mentions a deferral but omits the relevant reference and authorized status.

Could you confirm the reference and current authorized status with maintenance control? I need accurate coordination information; I cannot infer airworthiness from an incomplete note.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

04 | Irregular Operations and Passenger Communication

Passengers receive conflicting messages about a delay. The next departure estimate has not been confirmed.

I'm sorry for the conflicting information. We are waiting for a confirmed update from the responsible team. I'll share the next verified information and explain the available assistance through our process.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

05 | Ground Handling and Turnaround Performance

A turnaround handoff identifies an open ground-service task but does not name who accepted it.

This ground-service task is still open. Please confirm which team has accepted it and record the status in the agreed coordination channel before we describe the handoff as complete.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

06 | Security and Access Control

A visitor asks a staff member to bypass an access check because a meeting is running late.

I understand the meeting is urgent, but access still needs to follow the approved process. Let me contact the authorized team to arrange the appropriate check and escort if required.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

07 | Incident Reporting and Investigation

An initial incident note says equipment damage was caused by a specific action, although the review is incomplete.

The damage has been observed; its cause is still under review. I'll record the known sequence and distinguish witness reports from confirmed findings in the note.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

08 | Regulatory Audits and Readiness

An audit preparation list has current records for most staff but three records still need verification.

Most records have been checked; three remain unverified. I'll list those items, their owners, and the follow-up status so the audit update shows the outstanding work clearly.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

FAA: aviation English standard

https://www.faa.gov/regulations_policies/advisory_circulars/index.cfm/go/document.information/documentID/1031388

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.